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Chicago Tribune

$4.00 | THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 12, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

'BROADVIEW SIX' CASE

Judge slaps DOJ in rebuke

Effort to derail hearing draws 'extraordinary' response after Boutros, others told to testify

By Jason Meisner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

In another sign of the deepening credibility crisis for the Justice Department, a federal judge in Chicago said this week the government's professed confusion over an upcoming evidentiary hearing in the "Broadview Six" case was "immaterial" and that they failed to comply with her orders for discovery.

The back-and-forth between U.S. District Judge April Perry and Associate Attorney General Stanley Woodward, the No. 3 person at the Justice Department, has played out on the public docket this week and left many veteran Chicago attorneys shaking their heads.

It also sets up an unprecedented hearing currently set for Monday where U.S. Attorney Andrew Boutros and several assistants will have to testify under oath about their actions in the long-running Broadview Six case, which collapsed in May amid allegations of prosecutorial misconduct.

So far, efforts to limit or derail the hearing have been unsuccessful, and there are growing indications it could be an unprecedented

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Trump lawyer targets probes

White House makes threats in attempt to curb Dems' oversight

By Darlene Superville, Seung Min Kim and Joey Cappelletti
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — The White House has issued a warning to Democrats over their planned probes into the Trump administration, going as far as claiming that such investigations — a standard oversight function of Congress — may amount to "blatant criminality."

White House counsel Will Scharf issued the warning in a letter dated Monday to Rep. Robert Garcia of California, the top Democrat on the House Oversight Committee.

Garcia most likely would chair the powerful panel in the new Democratic-controlled Congress that is seated in January. Garcia warned Trump officials to "lawyer up" as his party was on the way to stunning victories in last week's midterm election.

In response, Scharf wrote that "threats to executive branch officials designed to deter them from public service, or process designed merely to abuse or instill fear in the recipient may cross the line into blatant criminality." The letter was first reported by Punchbowl News.

It's just the latest shot across the bow as the White House prepares to square off against newly empowered Democrats in the House and Senate next year, a showdown with major implications for congressional authority and the balance of power between the branches

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BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A patriotic presentation

A Junior ROTC honor guard from Lane Tech High School presents the colors Wednesday during the Veterans Day commemoration at Soldier Field in Chicago. Across the nation, ceremonies and memorials paid thanks to those who served. In Washington, President Donald Trump suggested the towering arch he wants to build in his own honor would also be dedicated to veterans, and a guard at the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier reprimanded a group with Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth for laughter after a ceremony. **Coverage in Nation & World**



OPEN FOR BUSINESS

Chicago's first self-cleaning public toilet launches in Polish Triangle

Christian Malatesta, the first member of the public to use Chicago's first public toilet, gives a thumbs-up upon exiting in the Polish Triangle on Wednesday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/TRIBUNE**

By Jake Sheridan
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

When Christian Malatesta took a midday bathroom break Wednesday, whatever he did made history.

The Wicker Park man shook hands with Ald. Daniel La Spata before an automatic door slid shut behind him, making Malatesta the inaugural user of Chicago's first self-cleaning public toilet. He had emailed La Spata weeks in advance to secure the honor.

Several minutes passed, then a muffled flush sounded through the walls of the stainless steel structure standing in the Polish Triangle. The door opened and the powder-room pioneer strutted out, two thumbs up in an initial review for a new piece of public infrastructure that could soon come to neighborhoods across the city.

"Great craftsmanship," he told a line of television cameras and a crowd filled with city bureaucrats.

It was a trip to the toilet years in the making.

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CPS parents, students protest Google AI rule

By Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago parents are pushing back on Google's announcement last week that K-12 school districts will lose access to its search engine if they switch off all the company's AI tools.

Dozens gathered outside Google's sleek Fulton Market office Wednesday, raising hand-painted signs and chanting as the rain beat down.

"The whole point of going to school is to be learning from actual people," said 16-year-old Reese Mackey, a junior at Kenwood Academy High School. "I don't want to learn from a bot."

Google said last week it would turn its Gemini chatbot and other AI tools off for schools unless administrators opt in, reversing an August decision that had made those services automatic.

But the catch? AI functions embedded in Google Search, including AI Mode and AI Overview, are too deeply integrated in the platform to shut off, company executives said. K-12 schools that restrict those functions will lose access to the search engine altogether.

Critics were quick to object, accusing Google of leveraging its dominance in online search to push deeper into the classroom. Google, for its part, said it was consulting with educators and adjusting its tools to limit interference with learning.

School districts across the nation, including Chicago Public Schools, have been publicly wrestling with AI integration in the classroom amid ongoing concerns about cheating and short-circuiting student learning.

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BUSINESS

Ferrara closing South Side plant

Ferrara, the century-old Chicago confectioner behind Nerds and other sugary candies, is closing its Little Village factory and laying off 154 employees in April. Manufacturing will be moving elsewhere, the company said.

SPORTS

No 'excuses' for Blackhawks' start

The Blackhawks are under a harsh spotlight amid their 4-13-1 start. On Wednesday, general manager Kyle Davidson stepped directly into the glare, taking blame and casting "full confidence" in coach Jeff Blashill.

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